transition, which includes SGPC president Harjinder Singh Dhami and figures less inclined to protect Sukhbir's interests, such as Satwant Kaur, daughter of Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale's close aide Amrik Singh.

The public admission of guilt as well as *tankha* are unprecedented for a sitting Akali Dal chief. Historically, leaders like Master Tara Singh, J.S. Talwandi and Surjit Singh Barnala had faced similar religious censures and struggled to reclaim their political footing. The next assembly election is due in February 2027. So, for Sukhbir, time may not be a constraint, but the sheer scale of his challenge is. While some view his humility in accepting wrongdoings and adhering to the punishment as a step toward redemption, critics argue these actions come too late to undo the damage to his reputation and his party's standing.

Amid the party's attempt at revival lies a crucial challenge: preventing radical elements from capturing the mainstream panthic space. The Lok Sabha victories of radicals like Amritpal Singh and Sarabjeet Singh Khalsa had signalled this drift, though with the SAD staying away from the recent assembly bypolls, the core Akali voters shifted decisively towards the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). For decades, the Badal family had worked to stabilise peace and expand the space for moderate Sikhs in Punjab. Thus, the radicals had been pushing for punitive measures to erase the Badals' influence. The Sikh clergy's actions, including revoking the title of *Panth Rattan Faqr-e-Quam* (Pearl of the Sect, Pride of the Community) bestowed on the late Parkash Singh Badal and withdrawing facilities from former Akal Takht chief Gurbachan Singh, align with these radical pressures.

The attack on Sukhbir by Chaura, a figure with a history of terror and smuggling activities, may also reflect this radical agenda. Ironically, Chaura had returned to India from his hideout in Pakistan under the Badal regime's efforts during 1997-2002. However, police suspect he continued supporting terrorist activities and pushing hardline panthic narratives. That said, this assassination bid is also a stark reminder of the volatile forces at play as Sukhbir and the Akali Dal navigate a precarious crossroads between reinvention and irrelevance. ■



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EYES ON THE NEXT BATTLE
Tejaswi Yadav addressing the media outside the Bihar assembly in Patna, Nov. 27

BIHAR/ RJD

TEJASWI'S QUOTA GAMBIT

By Amitabh Srivastava

In politics, timing is everything. On November 26, as the country celebrated its 75th Constitution Day, Tejaswi Yadav, the leader of the Opposition in Bihar, chose a moment of political vulnerability to make a bold demand in the state assembly. That of bringing in a new bill to raise the reservation limit in government jobs and educational institutions in Bihar to 85 per cent. Just three days before, the news hadn't been kind. In a bruising electoral debacle, Tejaswi's Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) had lost three critical bypolls; the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA), of which his party is a key constituent, failed to secure any of its four Bihar contests. So his policy proposal smelt very much like a political retort.

By invoking a theme central to his father and RJD patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav's legacy, Tejaswi is attempting a bold reclamation of old political territory that now stands cracked and fragmented: Bihar's teeming Other Backward Class (OBC) and Extremely Backward Class (EBC) groups. Referring to his tenure as deputy chief minister, he reminded the assembly, "You might recall, on November 9, 2023—my birthday—this assembly passed a resolution raising reservations to 65 per cent." This was based on Bihar's pioneering caste survey, which confirmed that the state's backwards spectrum in its entirety accounted for 63 per cent of the population. Emboldened by an old political common sense getting empirical validation, the